

What's the Use of Beauty? Poetry and the Purpose of Aesthetic Experience

An original lesson plan inspired by **Noel Jackson's** *Studies in Poetry: What's the Use of Beauty?* (MIT OpenCourseWare). Not affiliated with or endorsed by MIT OpenCourseWare or Noel Jackson. Explore the original course: <https://ocw.mit.edu/courses/21l-704-studies-in-poetry-whats-the-use-of-beauty-fall-2005/pages/syllabus/>

GRADE LEVEL	DURATION	TOPICS
Grades 10-12 (cross-listed English/Philosophy)	55 minutes	Aesthetics

“Does appreciating beauty make us better people in some way, or is beauty's value purely in the pleasure it gives us, with no further purpose required?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Plato's suspicion that poetry and imitative art can be morally and epistemically dangerous.
- Explain Kant's account of aesthetic judgment as “disinterested” yet claiming universal validity.
- Close-read a poem through both a formalist lens (focused on its craft) and a moral-educative lens (focused on what it might teach), and construct an argument about whether beauty serves a purpose beyond pleasure.

Materials Needed

- Copies of a single short poem for close reading (choose one with clear formal features and some ethically-resonant content — teacher's choice)
- Short excerpt handout: Plato's critique of poetry (Republic, Book X) and a short paraphrase of Kant's account of disinterested aesthetic judgment
- Two images or two pieces of music for the opening activity, ideally contrasting in style

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Which Is Better, and Why?

8 min

Show students two contrasting artworks (or play two short pieces of music) and ask them to vote on which is “better” and, more importantly, to articulate what they mean by “better” in this context. Collect a range of criteria on the board (technical skill, emotional impact, originality, moral content) — this list will map roughly onto the theories introduced next.

Direct Instruction: Plato's Suspicion and Kant's Disinterest

15 min

Introduce Plato's worry that poetry, as imitation, is doubly removed from truth and can inflame emotions in ways that undermine rational self-control — grounds for his famous (and famously controversial) proposal to restrict poets in his ideal city. Contrast this with Kant's very different framing: a judgment of beauty is “disinterested,” meaning it isn't tied to any desire to possess or use the object, yet it still claims universal validity — when you call something beautiful, you're implicitly claiming others ought to agree, even without a determinate argument to prove it.

Close Reading Activity

20 min

Distribute the chosen poem. In pairs, students first annotate it formally (meter, imagery, structure, sound devices) and then annotate it again for any ethical or educative content — what, if anything, does the poem seem to teach or model about how to feel or act? Ask pairs to note where the two readings reinforce each other and where they pull in different directions.

Small-Group Debate

9 min

Groups take a position: does this poem's value lie primarily in its craft and the pleasure it produces (a broadly Kantian, formalist answer), or in what it might teach or model for readers (closer to what Plato worried about, but reframed as a virtue rather than a danger)? Groups should be ready to defend their position with specific lines from the poem.

Closure

3 min

Return to the essential question. Ask for a quick show of hands: does beauty need a further purpose (moral, educative) to be valuable, or is the pleasure it produces enough on its own?

Discussion Questions

- 1 Is Plato right that art which stirs strong emotion could be dangerous to a person's rational self-control, or does this undersell what emotional engagement with art can teach us?
- 2 Kant says beauty judgments are “disinterested” — can you think of a case where your enjoyment of something beautiful was clearly tied to a personal interest or desire, complicating this claim?
- 3 If two people disagree about whether something is beautiful, is one of them simply wrong, or can both be right in some sense?
- 4 Does a poem or artwork have to be morally instructive to be great, or can a work be aesthetically excellent while being morally troubling or neutral?

Assessment

Students write a short response arguing whether the poem studied in class derives its value primarily from its craft, from what it teaches or models, or from some combination of the two — citing specific lines to support their claim.

Extension Activity

Have students bring in a song, film, or artwork of their own choosing and apply the same two lenses (formalist and moral-educative) used in class, presenting their analysis to a small group.

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